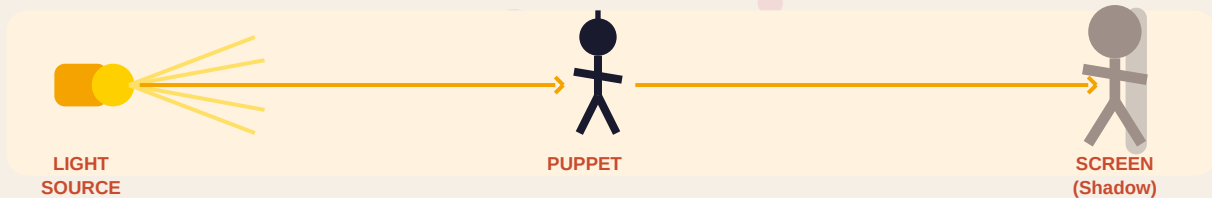




Shadow Puppet Theatre

Where Shadows Tell Magical Stories!

Subject	Arts & Science (Light & Shadow)
Grade	Grade 1 (Ages 5–7)
Duration	45–60 Minutes
Level	Beginner
Platform	Planrs Academy



"Shadows help us tell magical stories!"

SECTION 1 — Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

LO 1	Describe what a shadow is and explain how it is made.
LO 2	Name the three things needed to make a shadow: light, object, and screen.
LO 3	Make at least one hand shadow shape (bunny, dog, or duck).
LO 4	Create a simple shadow puppet from black paper and a stick.

LO 5	Tell a short story using their shadow puppet.
LO 6	Name at least one Indian shadow puppet tradition (Tolu Bommalata or Togalu Gombeyaata).
LO 7	Demonstrate how moving the puppet closer or farther changes the shadow size.

■ KEY VOCABULARY

TERM	MEANING
Shadow	A dark shape made when an object blocks light from a source like the sun or a torch.
Light Source	Something that produces light — the sun, a torch, a lamp, or a phone screen.
Puppet	A figure used to tell stories. It can be made from paper, cloth, leather, or hands.
Screen	A flat white surface (wall, bedsheet, paper) where the shadow appears.
Puppeteer	The person who holds and moves the puppet to bring it to life.
Silhouette	A dark outline shape — the kind of shape a shadow puppet makes.
Tolu Bommalata	Shadow puppet art from Andhra Pradesh — large leather puppets that tell Ramayana stories.
Togalu Gombeyaata	Shadow puppet art from Karnataka — funny puppets in many sizes that tell comic stories.

■ SECTION 2 — Concept Notes

1. What is a Shadow?

A shadow is a **dark shape** that appears on a surface like the ground or a wall. It forms when an object blocks light from passing through.

Shadows happen all around us — in the park when we play outside, when diyas glow on Diwali, and when a torch shines in a dark room.

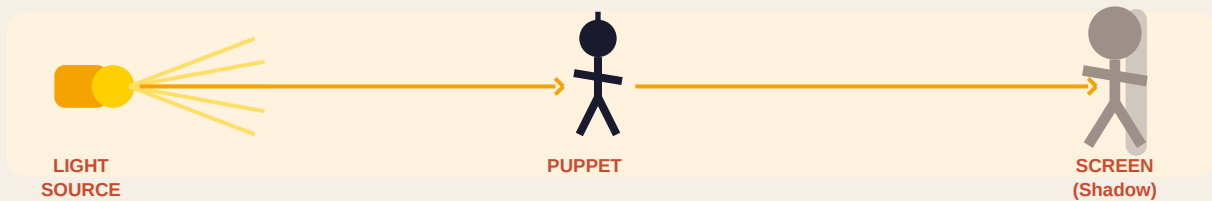
■■ *Indian Example: On Diwali, the little diya flame makes pretty dancing shadows on the walls at home!*

2. Three Things You Need to Make a Shadow

WHAT YOU NEED	EXAMPLE	FUN FACT
LIGHT SOURCE	The sun, a torch, a lamp, or even a mobile phone screen.	<i>The brighter the light, the darker and sharper the shadow!</i>

OBJECT	Something that blocks the light — a puppet, your hand, a tree, your body.	<i>Opaque objects make the best shadows.</i>
SCREEN	A flat white surface where the shadow appears — a wall, bedsheet, or white paper.	<i>The farther from the light, the larger the shadow!</i>

How it Works — The Shadow Diagram



Light travels in straight lines. When the puppet blocks the light, it cannot reach the screen behind it — so a dark shape (shadow) appears there instead!

3. What is a Puppet?

A puppet is a **fun figure** used to tell stories. It can look like a person, an animal, or anything you can imagine! Puppets can be made from paper, cloth, clay, or even your own hands.

Puppets can move and dance! Puppeteers hold them on sticks and make them walk, jump, and talk during the story.

4. The Screen — Where Shadows Appear

The screen is the flat white place where we watch the shadow show. It can be a classroom wall, a white bedsheet hung up, or even a big piece of white paper!

When the puppeteer holds the puppet between the light and the screen, the shadow appears on the screen — just like a movie!

5. Shadow Size — A Cool Science Fact!

PUPPET POSITION	SHADOW SIZE	WHY?
Close to the light	Very BIG shadow	Blocks a large angle of light rays
In the middle	Medium shadow	Blocks a medium angle of light rays
Close to the screen	Small shadow	Blocks only a small angle of light rays

■ SECTION 3 — Indian Shadow Puppet Traditions

India has a rich tradition of shadow puppet theatre. These art forms have been passed down through families for hundreds of years!

TOLU BOMMALATA

Shadow Puppets from Andhra Pradesh

Tolu Bommalata puppets are big and made from leather. They tell stories from the Ramayana — one of India's greatest epics. The puppets have joints so they can move their arms and legs. Skilled artists hold sticks to make

TOGALU GOMBEYAATA

Shadow Puppets from Karnataka

Togalu Gombeyaata puppets are made from leather and come in many sizes — some big, some tiny! These puppets tell funny, comic stories that make everyone laugh. Puppeteers use silly voices and fast movements.

Comparison: Tolu Bommalata vs Togalu Gombeyaata

FEATURE	TOLU BOMMALATA	TOGALU GOMBEYAATA
From	Andhra Pradesh	Karnataka
Material	Leather (goat/deer hide)	Leather
Stories	Ramayana, Mahabharata	Comic tales, folklore
Puppet Size	Very large	Many sizes — big to tiny
Mood	Grand and dramatic	Funny and playful
Joints	Yes — arms and legs move	Yes — flexible movement

SECTION 4 — Session Plan (45–60 Minutes)

TIME	SEGMENT	WHAT HAPPENS
0:00–5:00	Wonder Moment	Start with hand shadows! Dim the lights. Shine a torch on the wall and make a bunny. Ask: 'Can you do this too?'
5:00–10:00	What is a Shadow?	Teach the concept: shadow = dark shape formed when object blocks light. Use the sun, diyas, torch as examples.
10:00–15:00	What is a Puppet?	Show images of puppets made from paper, cloth, hands. Explain how puppets move and tell stories.
15:00–18:00	Light is Important	Discuss light sources: sun, torch, lamp, phone. Demonstrate: brighter light = darker shadow.
18:00–22:00	The Screen	Show how a wall or bedsheet works as a screen. Demonstrate the light → puppet → screen setup.
22:00–28:00	Indian Puppets	Show images of Tolu Bommalata (Andhra Pradesh) and Togalu Gombeyaata (Karnataka). Share key facts.
28:00–35:00	Try Hand Shadows!	Students try making duck, dog, and bunny shapes. Move hands closer/farther to see size change.
35:00–45:00	Make Your Own Puppet	Students cut a shape from black paper, tape it to a stick. Teacher circulates and helps with cutting.

45:00–55:00	Tell a Story	Each student (or pair) presents a 3-sentence shadow story. Starter: 'One day, my [animal] went to...'
55:00–60:00	Wrap Up & Celebrate	Success criteria check. Safety pledge. Students clap for themselves — they are now shadow puppet storytellers!

Materials Needed

For the Teacher	A torch or strong lamp, white bedsheet or blank wall, dark room or dim space.
For Each Student	1 sheet of black chart paper, safe child scissors, 1 pencil or ice cream stick, sticky tape.
Optional	White A4 paper (as individual screens), extra black paper for more puppets.

✂️ SECTION 5 — Classroom Activities

Activity A — Hand Shadow Exploration

Using just your hands and a light source, make shadow animals on the wall.

SHADOW	HOW TO MAKE IT
BUNNY	Hold up two fingers (index + middle) together. Curl the other fingers. Make two tall ears!
DOG	Open your hand flat. Fold your thumb across your palm. Your four fingers = the dog's face!
DUCK	Put all fingertips together like a beak. Open and close them to make it quack!
BIRD	Cross both thumbs together. Spread all fingers wide. Flap your hands like wings!

Activity B — Make Your Own Shadow Puppet

Follow these 4 steps to create your very own shadow puppet!

1 Get black chart paper and safe scissors. Ask a grown-up to help you cut!

2 Draw and cut out a fun shape — an animal, a person, a tree, or anything you like!

3 Tape or tie your puppet shape firmly to a pencil or ice cream stick. Hold it tight!

4 Set up your screen (wall or white paper). Shine the torch and watch your shadow appear!

Activity C — Tell a Story With Your Puppet

Use your puppet to share a magical shadow story! Follow these steps:

1

Start your story: "One day, my [animal/character] went to the forest..."

2

Say 2–3 short sentences about what happens next in your story.

3

Show your puppet's shadow on the screen while you talk!

4

Use different voices for your characters to make it exciting!

Story Starter Examples:

"One day, my little bunny found a golden seed in the forest..."

"One day, a brave little dog helped a lost bird find its home..."

"One day, my duck went to the river and met a friendly frog..."

⇒ SECTION 6 — Worksheet Activities

Worksheet A — Fill in the Blank

Complete each sentence with the correct word from the word box.

Word Box: shadow | light | puppet | screen | stick | dark | wall | leather

1. A _____ is a dark shape made when something blocks the light.
2. Without _____, we cannot make any shadows.
3. A _____ is a figure used to tell stories.
4. The _____ is the flat white surface where we see the shadow.
5. We tape our puppet shape to a _____ or pencil.
6. Tolu Bommalata puppets are made from _____ in Andhra Pradesh.

Worksheet B — True or False

Circle TRUE or FALSE for each statement.

STATEMENT	TRUE	FALSE
Shadows are bright and colourful.	☐	☐
You need light to make a shadow.	☐	☐
Moving the puppet closer to the light makes the shadow bigger.	☐	☐
Tolu Bommalata puppets are made from cloth.	☐	☐
The screen is where we watch the shadow show.	☐	☐
A puppet can only be made from hands — not paper.	☐	☐
Togalu Gombeyaata comes from Karnataka.	☐	☐

Worksheet C — Draw Your Shadow Puppet Setup

In the box below, draw: 1) A light source 2) Your puppet 3) The screen with a shadow on it.

Label the three parts: LIGHT, PUPPET, SHADOW —■

■ SECTION 7 — Quick Quiz (6 Questions)

Tick (✓) the correct answer for each question.

Q1. What is a shadow?

- A) A bright coloured shape
- B) A dark shape formed when an object blocks light ✓
- C) A type of puppet made from cloth

Q2. Which of these makes a shadow BIGGER?

- A) Moving the puppet close to the screen
- B) Moving the puppet close to the light source ✓
- C) Making the screen smaller

Q3. What is a screen in shadow puppet theatre?

- A) A mobile phone
- B) A colourful painting

C) A flat white surface like a wall or bedsheet ✓

Q4. Tolu Bommalata puppets come from which Indian state?

- A) Karnataka
- B) Andhra Pradesh ✓
- C) Rajasthan

Q5. Which three things do you need to make a shadow?

- A) Paper, scissors, glue
- B) Light, object, and screen ✓
- C) Water, paint, and a cloth

Q6. Togalu Gombeyaata puppets tell what kind of stories?

- A) Sad and serious stories
- B) Only stories from the Ramayana
- C) Funny, comic stories ✓

■ ANSWER KEY (Teacher Copy)

Fill in the Blank Answers:

1. shadow | 2. light | 3. puppet | 4. screen | 5. stick | 6. leather

True or False Answers:

1. FALSE | 2. TRUE | 3. TRUE | 4. FALSE | 5. TRUE | 6. FALSE | 7. TRUE

Quiz Answers:

Q1: B) A dark shape formed when an object blocks light

Q2: B) Moving the puppet close to the light source

Q3: C) A flat white surface like a wall or bedsheet

Q4: B) Andhra Pradesh

Q5: B) Light, object, and screen

Q6: C) Funny, comic stories

■ SECTION 8 — Success Criteria

Students have succeeded when they can:

✓	Make at least one shadow shape with hands or a paper puppet
✓	Attach a puppet shape to a stick or pencil correctly
✓	Explain what a shadow is in one simple sentence

✓	Name the three things needed to make a shadow: light, object, screen
✓	Tell a short story (3+ sentences) using their shadow puppet
✓	Name one Indian shadow puppet tradition and describe it briefly
✓	Show how moving the puppet changes the shadow size

Celebrate! ■

"You did amazing work today! You learned about shadows, light, puppets, and India's beautiful puppet traditions. Keep making shadows and telling magical stories at home!"

You are now a Shadow Puppet Storyteller!